

The Ink-bamboos of Wen Yü-k'o:
The Creative Moment in Su Tung-p'o's Aesthetic Theory

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PREVIEW

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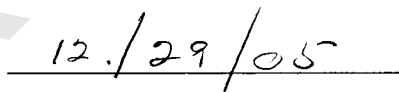
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Robert J. Poor

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GRADUATE SCHOOL

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With profound thanks to Robert J. Poor, my advisor, for his inspired teaching and sense of freedom, who always leaves an unexplored spaciousness for his students to enter alone; to whom I feel, as Huang T'ing-chien once wrote of Su, "somewhere between a teacher and a friend."

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¹ “As all humanistic studies focus upon the activities and works of man as they appear under varying historical conditions, we are all in a sense ‘cultural historians,’ but the art historian takes as his point of departure the work of art as a concrete expression of the human mind and heart. Inevitably, in the process of investigation, he trespasses on the domains of various specialized historical studies and may find himself, despite his best efforts, sinking into rather deep methodological waters, but he takes courage in the fact that only through such incursions, however problematic, can he contribute in a broad fashion to cultural history.” Marilyn Wong Fu and Shen C. Y. Fu, Studies in Connoisseurship: Chinese Paintings from the Arthur M. Sackler Collection in New York and Princeton (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1973), pp. 18-19.

Dedication

To Peter, my husband

To Maia, Alex and Nedjo, my children

To Susan, my sister

For your sharing, your liveliness, and your love

Abstract

In eleventh century China a new aesthetic emerged, most fully articulated by the poet Su Tung-p'o 蘇東坡 (Su Shih 蘇軾) (1037-1101) and most fully exemplified in his writings on the ink-bamboo paintings of Wen T'ung 文同 (1018-1079), known best as Yü-k'o 與可 or Wen Yü-k'o 文與可. This dissertation is an inquiry into the core of Su's aesthetic theory, locating it in the context of both the cultural tradition and the broader foundations of Chinese philosophical thought. It traces the process by which Su describes the humanizing quality of creative engagement. It is based upon my translations of the poems, prose and inscriptions upon paintings, scattered throughout his oeuvre, that comprise that core. I use supporting materials drawn from his writings on calligraphy, poetry and music, as well as classical texts from Chinese aesthetics and philosophy. The central issue is the moment of creativity, which Su sees as beginning in a fusion of the objective and the subjective, executed in a swift moment of entrusting or forgetting, and resulting in a significance that lies beyond the image. As seen through the eyes of Su, the ink-bamboos of Wen Yü-k'o represent an integrated vision of life that relates the spontaneous moment of creativity to deep and underlying values of the Chinese cultural tradition.

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Introduction

If you want to paint, you must first shut your eyes and sing.

Picasso

In the ink-bamboo paintings of his friend Wen Yü-k'o 文與可 (Wen T'ung 文同) (1018-1079), the eleventh century Chinese poet and literatus Su Tung-p'o 蘇東坡, or Su Shih 蘇軾 (1037-1101) found the freshness and purity that he prized in poetry, and in Yü-k'o's way of painting a spontaneity and authenticity that he felt was central to the cultural tradition. His writings on the subject of Wen Yü-k'o's ink-bamboos became the foundation of a new aesthetic which changed the course of Chinese painting and inaugurated the tradition of literati painting.

Su Tung-p'o was a cherished poet and revered statesman of the Northern Sung dynasty (960-1127). He is remembered as something of a humanist ideal, not only for his poetry, but also for his imprisonment and two exiles resulting from his criticism and even ridicule of government policies which he felt were detrimental to the culture. Of his poetry, Kojiro Yoshikawa writes that Su's ability to transcend his own

sufferings initiated a new era in Chinese poetry, one characterized by a more optimistic tenor: “The preoccupation with sorrow which had become a habit with the poets of earlier ages was brought to an end by his efforts, and poetry was led into the direction of a more hopeful view of life.”¹ That transcendence had an effect well beyond the poetic tradition; Michael Fuller writes that “the image of Su finding joy even in the worst of adversity has become part of the Chinese cultural heritage.”² As a calligrapher, Su is counted among the four great calligraphers of the dynasty, and certainly an impetus to the flowering of diversity and expressiveness that occurred in calligraphy in the last two decades of the eleventh century. Of Yü-k’o, we know more through Su than we do through historical accounts. The Sung dynasty history, the Sung shih, writes of his “bosom resonance;” the eleventh-century art historian Kuo Jo-hsü 郭若虛, writing before 1074, ranks him in an extraordinarily small group of thirteen “princes, nobles and scholars” who “wander in the arts,” a reference the Confucian idea of the role of the arts.³

As a poet, the moment of creativity was of great interest to Su. His own experience of the creative process is probably the basis of his understanding of Yü-k’o’s ink-bamboo paintings, done with the same swiftness and spontaneity with which Su wrote his own poetry.

¹ Kojiro Yoshikawa, An Introduction to Sung Poetry, Harvard-Yenching Monograph Series, XVII (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 1967), p. 118.

² Michael A. Fuller, The Road to East Slope: The Development of Su Shi's Poetic Voice (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1990), p. 251.

³ Kuo Jo-hsü, discussing the period between 960 and 1074, writes: “Of princes, nobles, and scholar-officials who have ‘followed the dictates of loving-kindness and sought recreation in the arts,’ attaining the utmost therein, there have been thirteen men, as follows.” In Alexander C. Soper, trans. and ann., Kuo Jo-Hsü’s “Experiences in Painting” (T’u-hua chien-wen chih): An Eleventh Century History of Chinese Painting Together with the Chinese Text in Facsimile (Washington, D.C.: American Council of Learned Societies, 1951), p. 41. The full passage, Analects 7.6, is “Set your intention on the Way, rely on integrity, follow human-heartedness, and wander in the arts 志於道據於德依於仁游於藝.”

Su saw Yuko's paintings as a record of the moment in which they were painted, a timeless moment out of which springs an image containing the very breath of life. This moment, according to Su, emerges from emptiness, and has at its heart the merging of the knower and the known. Su sees such a moment as inspired, and sees the one who does it as one who has tao.

To Su, this creative moment involves a sense of the one-ness of things, resulting in an intuitive glimpse into the inner nature of the subject. He felt that entrusting oneself to the spontaneity of that moment is a distinctive state of creative engagement entailing one's very being. Paintings which are the product of this creative state are qualitatively different from paintings which do not derive from this experience. Rather than being principally a delineation of the form of the thing painted, the painting carries over the purity and freshness with which it was created, evoking something beyond the form, a characteristic we might call resonance.

Su broadened the concept of wen 文, the Chinese cultural tradition, to include painting. His sense of tao 道 included not only the Confucian Way of the Sages, but also the unmediated sense of life inspired by Taoist philosophy and Ch'an Buddhism. Ch'an, the forerunner of Zen, was the most sinicized form of Buddhism, in part for its absorption of philosophical Taoism. It was the most influential of the Buddhist schools in the Northern Sung dynasty; Ch'an monks were educated and literate in the Confucian classics, and Confucian scholars such as Su were often frequent visitors to Ch'an temples. As a Confucian scholar of the highest accomplishment, Su was educated to embody the Confucian cultural tradition. But his writings are peppered with imagery from Chuang-tzu, and infused with a sense of the moment unique to Ch'an. His vivid integration of these three traditions, appreciating their uniqueness while drawing upon their commonalities, is foundational to his view

of the creative moment in painting, a view which itself is marked by the freshness and newness that he so highly valued.

PREVIEW

Chapter I. Becoming One with Bamboo

In contemplating the creative process, and in particular the spontaneous moment of creation in painting, Su wrote of a sense of oneness with things, a heightened awareness that one's intrinsic being is part of the whole of existence. While serving at the capital in 1087, Su wrote a poem upon a scroll bearing a painting of ink-bamboo by Wen Yü-k'o. The scroll was in the collection of Ch'ao Pu-chih 晁補之 (1053-1110), one of Su's younger friends and disciples. The poem reads:

When Yü-k'o painted bamboo,
He saw bamboo only, never people.
Was it only that he saw no people?
So rapt, he left even himself behind.

He became one with the bamboo,
Inexhaustibly putting forth purity and freshness.
For Chuang-tzu, the world didn't even exist.⁴
Who now understands this congealing of spirit?⁵

⁴ Chuang-tzu 莊子 (fourth century B.C.), a mystic appreciated for the brilliance of his wit, is considered to be one of the two foundational philosophers of Taoism, along with Lao-tzu 老子 (sixth century B.C.). The works attributed to them, the Chuang-tzu 莊子 and the Tao te ching 道德經 respectively, became the basis of philosophical Taoism, as distinct from religious Taoism, which was evidently a later formation. Chuang-tzu's historical name, Chuang Chou 莊周, is used by Su in the text of the poem.

與可畫竹時
見竹不見人
豈獨不見人
嗒然遺其身

其身與竹化
無窮出清新
莊周世無有
誰知此凝神

Did Yü-k'o become one with the whole of existence? No. He became one with the thing at hand, the bamboos that he loved. In painting his ink-bamboos he became one with them: is there any other way to really understand anything? He was so rapt, so empathetically identified with them, that he left behind any awareness of himself. As a result of his immersion in that moment of oneness, he put forth a purity and freshness that is inherent in the bamboos and also in Yü-k'o in that moment. He became one with them, and this inner resonance is what he was painting. Who can understand this amazing thing? Certainly Chuang-tzu would have, for whom the affairs of the world meant very little.

Su uses two terms that he considers central to genuine creative engagement. The first is ch'ing 清, meaning “purity” or “clarity,” and the second is hsin 新, meaning “newness” or “freshness.” These characteristics, which Su feels are also the characteristics of poetry that comes from genuine creative engagement, are put forth

⁵ Su Shih, “Shu Ch'ao Pu-chih suo-ts'ang Yü-k'o hua-chu”

書晁補之所藏與可畫

(Written on a painting of bamboo by Yü-k'o in

Ch'ao Pu-chih's collection), first of three, in Su Shih shih-chi 蘇軾詩集

(Collected

Poems of Su Shih), commentary by Wang Wen-gao (b. 1764), edited by K'ung Fan-li (Peking:

Chung-hua shu-chü, 1992) (hereinafter referred to as SSSC), 29:1522-1523.

by Yü-k'o because of this experience of becoming one with the bamboos. As a result, the painting itself has a freshness and purity that seems to Su to be endless.

Su writes of the process in transformative terms, not only in Yü-k'o becoming one with bamboo, but also in his characterization of the painting as a “congealing of spirit.” The literal translation of “He became one with the bamboo” is “his self into bamboo was transformed” (ch'i shen yü chu hua 其身與竹化), using the character hua 化, “transform.” In addition, Su describes the painting as a “congealing of spirit,” (ning shen 凝神) suggesting a materialization of something from a more fluid state, as water congeals into ice, indicated by the “ice” radical in the character “congeal” (ning 凝). Shen 神, here “spirit,” is often also translated as “divine,” a distinctly accessible quality that humans can and do aspire to. Mencius 孟子 (fourth century B.C.), the second foundational philosopher of Confucianism, uses shen 神 to characterize the sage, sheng 聖, as one who has transcended knowledge.⁶ Su's use of the term ning shen 凝神 then, suggests that the painting has the quality of transforming something of spirit, that is, transcendent of knowledge, into something more palpable.

The idea of going beyond knowledge and a forgetting of both self and object is found in a passage concerning China's earliest named painter of whose works we still have something, Ku K'ai-chih 顧愷之 (ca. 345-ca. 406). The T'ang dynasty scholar and art historian Chang Yen-Yüan 張彥遠, in his ninth-century “Record of the Famous Painters of all the Dynasties” (Li-tai ming-hua chi 歷代名畫記) (847 A.D.), wrote of Ku: “Thing and self both forgotten, he

⁶ Mencius VIIIB25, in Mencius, translated by D. C. Lau, 2 vols. (Hong Kong: The Chinese University Press, 1984), pp. 296-297. “Mencius” is the Latinized version of Meng-tzu 孟子, the name by which he is known in Chinese.

abandoned form and departed from knowledge.”

(物我兩忘離形去智) ⁷ Although the text is somewhat telegraphic, we see the idea that form is not what is painted, that the act of painting does not involve knowledge, and an implication that the distinction between self and object is forgotten. In both it is suggested that inessentials drop away and what is painted is not a delineation of external form but something beyond that.

As in Yü-k'o's experience with the bamboos, a moment of oneness with things and a forgetting of self are often found in Chinese poetry. Su wrote of such a moment and a forgetting in a poem written by T'ao Ch'ien 陶潛 (T'ao Yüan-ming 陶淵明, 365-427), the fifth-century poet who left his appointment as a scholar-official to return home--which to him meant to return to the spontaneous unfoldment of the life-process, tzu-jan 自然, and to return to himself as well.⁸ His poems are particularly appreciated for their quality of personal voice. Su felt a great affinity with T'ao, and wrote on one of T'ao's poems:

The delight of reading the poem lies in the fact that suddenly, without purpose, the poet's mind and his surroundings are unified, as he gazes at the mountains while picking flowers.⁹

T'ao's poem reads:

⁷ Chang Yen-Yüan 張彥遠, Li-tai ming-hua chi 歷代名畫記 (Record of the Famous Painters of all the Dynasties) (847 A.D.), II:III. My translation is adapted from William R. B. Acker, Some T'ang and Pre-T'ang Texts on Chinese Painting, 2 vols. (Sinica Leidensia, vols. 8, 12) (Leiden: Brill, 1954, 1974), vol. 1, p. 192.

⁸ See David Hinton, The Selected Poems of T'ao Ch'ien (Port Townsend, Washington: Copper Canyon Press, 1993), 5-6.

⁹ Su Shih, "T'i Yüan-ming yin chiu shih hou", T'ao Yüan-ming chan chiu tzui liao hui-pien (Peking: Chung-hua shu-chü, 1962), 1:29. Translated by Chang Chung-yüan, Creativity and Taoism: a study of Chinese philosophy, art and poetry (New York: Harper & Row, 1963), p. 20.

I built my hut near others,
But away from the clamor of carriages and horses.

You ask me: Now, how can this be?
When the mind is far-off, any place you are is remote.

Gathering chrysanthemums below the eastern fence,
I absently glimpse the southern mountains.

The mountain air at sunset is beautiful,
Flocking birds are returning home.

This all has such profound meaning to me,
But when I try to explain it, I have forgotten words.¹⁰

結廬在人境
而無車馬喧

問君何能爾？
心遠地自偏

採菊東籬下
悠然見南山

山氣日夕佳
飛鳥相與還

此中有真意
欲辨已忘言

¹⁰ T'ao Ch'ien, "Yin chiu 飲酒" (Drinking Wine), in T'ao Yüan-ming chi, Lu Chin-li chiao-chu. (Peking: Chung-hua shu-chü, 1979), p. 89.

To Su, nearly seven hundred years later, the poem has the freshness of the present moment. He expresses delight, not only for T'ao's moment of oneness with his surroundings, holding chrysanthemums and glimpsing the far-off mountains, but also for its suddenness, unbidden and without purpose.

As with Yü-k'o among the bamboos, T'ao experiences a forgetting. His immersion in that moment damages his ability to fluently communicate in words, something he as a poet felt as a part of his life. And, as with Yü-k'o among the bamboos, T'ao's experience is a momentary immersion in what Osvald Sirén might call the "suchness" of things.

T'ao has been characterized as "the first writer to make a poetry of his natural voice and immediate experience, thereby creating the personal lyricism which all major Chinese poets inherited and made their own."¹¹ Su felt so close to this poet that he wrote poems harmonizing with nearly all of the poems in T'ao's oeuvre.¹² It is possible that the "purity" (ch'ing 清) to which Su often refers as a value which he highly appreciates in the context of both poetry and painting is a purity or clarity of personal voice found in T'ao's poems.

T'ao's momentary and sudden sense of being unified with his surroundings has a parallel in an extraordinary direct quote from Yü-k'o himself concerning his experience of oneness with the bamboos. It is located in a fu, a prose-poem written by Su's brother Su Ch'e 蘇轍 (1039-1112), that is an account of a conversation

¹¹ Hinton, T'ao Ch'ien, 5.

¹² Writing harmonizing poems was a playful practice among Sung poets, matching the rhymes of a friend's poem. For Su's poems matching T'ao's, see Ronald C. Egan, Word, Image and Deed in the Life of Su Shih (Harvard-Yenching Institute Monograph Series 39. Cambridge (Mass.) and London: Harvard University Press, 1994), pp. 232-237.

between Yü-k'o and an unnamed visitor, clearly Su himself. The fu begins with the visitor eloquently exclaiming about the ink-bamboo he has just witnessed being painted by Yü-k'o, and the process by which it was created:

Ink-bamboo fu

Yü-k'o made bamboo with ink, and looked upon it as good.

The visitor, seeing it, was astonished and said: "Today you have received a mandate from heaven and given it form on earth--drenched in rain and dew, tossing in the wind's breath."¹³ In the spring, its tight buds shoot forth; in summer they loosen and spread out, opening into branches and putting forth leaves until winter, when it is complete. Its nature is unyielding and pure, separate and straight. Yet its appearance is graceful and elegant, supple and lovely. It passes through the changes of winter and summer, and withstands the chaste discipline of frost and snow. It is of one breath with the grasses and trees, sharing the same soil, yet its nature is different. Truly, as to the spontaneity of things springing into existence, is it only creation that is able to do this?

Today you grind the soot of a green pine and twist the hairs of a rabbit's fur. Disdaining walls, you splatter the silk, painting freely. In a moment it is finished, lush and rustling, crooked and straight, crosswise and slanting, thickly clustered and finely delicate, short and tall. You have seized the hidden thoughts of a created thing and composed a living idea in an exalted moment. Are you not, sir, one who possesses tao?"

¹³ The passage beginning with "drenched in rain and dew" and ending with "yet its nature is different" is the first of two previously untranslated passages.

Yü-k'o listening, laughed and said: "Honored sir, what I love is tao! I have let go of bamboo! When I began my seclusion on the sunny side of Mt. Ch'ung, I made a thatched hut in a grove of tall bamboos. I beheld them and listened to them in silence, without conceptualizing them in my mind. In the morning I wandered among the bamboos, and by evening they became my friends. Eating and drinking in the midst of the bamboos, resting and sleeping in their shade, I saw that the transformations of the bamboo were many. As [for example] when the wind ceases and the rain clears, when the mountains become empty and the sun comes out--ah! how luxuriant they are, filling the whole valley, their leaves iridescent as kingfisher feathers, their skin like blue-green jade.¹⁴ They are tranquil in their restraint, like clouds gathered before rain. When cicadas cry out and birds chirp, and the echoes of humans grow silent, suddenly on the wind is a long sighing sound, murmuring, hidden, which continues through the whole day.

"Their tender shoots contain the first leaves; their roots coil easily through the earth. When their path is cut off by a valley torrent, their tendrils spread out and disperse. They scatter their seed by the tens of thousands, and become so dense an undergrowth that axes and hatchets are needed. In mountain rocks and stony soil where thorns and brambles grow, if one tries to pull them one will not succeed; even when broken they still hold on. When their vital energy is disturbed they become stronger; when their bodies are already ill they become increasingly wonderful. When the cold wind wails in fissures and caves, when the flying snow congeals on the banks and on ponds, they feel sympathy for the many trees with no one to rely on-- though they may be one hundred spans in

¹⁴ The passage beginning with "As [for example]" and ending with "this is what a human-hearted person (jen-jen 仁人) does" is the second of two previously untranslated passages.

circumference they have no support. They continue to be green even after the cold has come, shivering but without the appearance of being pitiable. They follow the pine and the cypress as an image of the self. In my humble opinion, this is what a human-hearted person does. This is what makes it bamboo!

“At the beginning, I saw them and delighted in them; now I delight in them but I don’t know why. Suddenly, forgetting the brush in my hand and the paper in front of me, all at once, in exhilaration, tall bamboos become a forest. Although Heaven’s creation was done without me; still, how is it different from this?”

The visitor said: “I have heard that Cook Ting cut up oxen, yet a nourisher of life took it [as a teaching]; that Wheelwright P’ien chiseled wheels, yet the reader of books [learned from it]. The ten thousand things all have a single li; it is where they come from that make them different. Now, then, honored sir, you have entrusted yourself to these bamboos, and so I take you to be one who has tao; is this not so?” Yü-k’o said: “Yes! yes!”¹⁵

墨竹賦

與可以墨為竹視之良竹也客見
而驚曰今夫受命於天賦形於地

涵濡雨露
振蕩風氣
春而萌芽

¹⁵ Su Ch’e 蘇轍 (1039-1112), “Mo-chu fu” 墨竹賦 (Ink-bamboo fu), in Su Ch’e 蘇轍, Luan-ch’eng chi 樂城集 (Collected Works) (Shanghai: Shanghai ku chi ch’u pan she, 1987), 1:416-417.

夏而解弛
散柯布葉
逮冬而遂
性剛絜而疏直
姿嬋娟以閑媚
涉寒暑之徂變
傲冰雪之凌厲
均一氣於草木
嗟壤同而性異
信物生之自然
雖造化其能使

今予研青松之煤
運脫兔之毛
睥睨牆堵
振灑繪綃
須臾而成
鬱乎蕭騷
曲真橫斜
穠纖庫高
竊造物之潛思
賦生意於崇朝
子豈誠有道者耶

與可聽然而笑曰
夫子之所好者道也
放乎竹矣

始子隱乎崇山之陽
廬乎脩竹之林
視聽漠然無概乎予心
朝與竹乎為游
莫與竹乎為朋
飲食乎竹間偃息乎竹陰